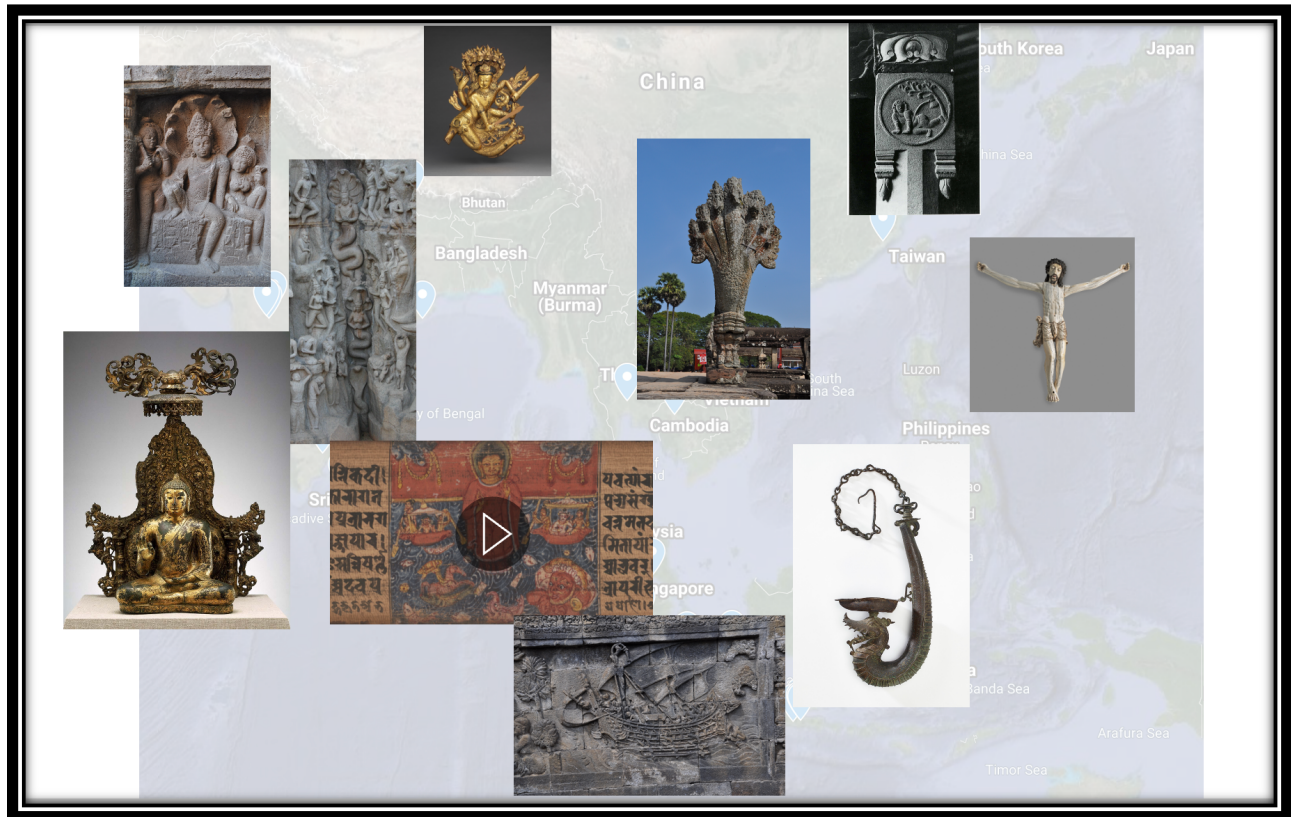


HAA 81 Art of Monsoon Asia: Interconnected Histories

Class Project: Mapping Visual and Material Culture of Southern Asia



Throughout the semester, we will learn about and research the visual and material culture of Monsoon Asia focusing on the regions of South and Southeast Asia. Referred to as “Southern Asia” for short, the focused geographic area includes the Himalayas, the Indian sub-continent, and Maritime and Mainland Southeast Asia. Culturally and historically, these geographic areas were deeply interconnected, but early Orientalist scholarship on the region followed a hegemonic, diffusionist model of cultural transfers in understanding the relationship between South and Southeast Asia, as discussed in the first lecture. As more recent scholarship has shown, looking at the archaeological and art historical evidence can help write new narratives about the dynamic historical connections and engagements between different regions of Monsoon Asia. To this end, we will harness the power of digital humanities tools to identify and research objects, motifs, and sites and locate them on a map, making little known connections across time and space.

You will choose from the following three categories to pursue your own project. In each category, you will choose a few examples (2 minimum for sites, 4 minimum for objects/iconography, 3 minimum for itinerant objects/routes; you may identify new examples if relevant) to delve deeper into and find information about each. For each item, you will prepare an entry following a provided [template](#) for metadata recording. The free-text description

section (100-200 words for objects/150-250 words for the other categories) in each entry should be your own writing, locating your object/site/route in the larger historical and cultural context. Your entry should explain the basic historical information and provide a short visual analysis. You should make the entries ready to tag any related contents (or create new tags). See the rubrics for further information.

Three Categories

Objects/motifs/iconography

✓Examples

Naga/nagini, makara, kunti/kendi (sprouted water vessel), vajra, bell (ghanta), Gangadhara (iconography), Churning the Ocean of Milk (iconography), Krishna subduing the naga king Kaliya (iconography), Buddha protected by the naga king Muchalinda (iconography), stylized clouds (motif), lotus (motif), purnagatha (motif), boat/ship (image/object), Tamil Buddha in MFA (object), Buddha in abhaya mudra (iconography), multi-roofed towering architecture (architectural type), rivers (iconography/image type), any other Monsoon Asia related objects in Harvard Art Museums

Sites/Monuments

✓Examples

Water architecture- step wells, water tanks (Ref. Hegewald 2002), fountains of the Kathmandu valley (Ref. DANAM); Sun Temples – Modhera, Gujarat, Konarak, Odisha; Rock-cut architecture- Ajanta, Ellora, Maharashtra; Pallava Sites in Mamallapuram, Kanchipuram, Chola sites in Thanjavur, Gangaikonda Cholapuram, Nagapattinam; Amaravati in Andhra; Monumental standing Buddha at Anuradhapura, and Polonnaruwa (Buddhist sites of Sri Lanka); Candi Borobudur, Candi Mendut, Candi Kalasan, Candi Plaosan, Prambanan, Candi Suku, Candi Sewu, Candi Jolotundo, Candi Jago, Candi Penataran, all in Java (Indonesia, See the [Sacred Sites in Southeast Asia page](#)); Kedah, Malacca Strait (today's Malaysia); Angkor Wat, Neak Pean, Angkor Thom, Western Mebon (all in Cambodia); Dvaravati, Ayuthaya, Thailand; Champa sites such as Myson, Dong Doun and ports (today's Vietnam)

Routes/Itinerant objects

✓Examples

Routes

Chinese pilgrims' itineraries known from Chinese records (Ref. Sen 2006; a list made for the class can be found [here](#).) Amoghavajra's itinerary, Atisha's itinerary, Itinerary of Chola Naval expeditions, merchant stories in Buddhist, Hindu, and Sufi narratives, may include other "sites/ports" like Strait of Malacca on the [course Google Map](#)

Itinerant objects (*to be linked with the routes)

Amulets (dharanis, miniature votive objects), miniature metal statues, miniature models, ritual implements (vajra/ghanta/staff), textiles, ceramics, coins, jewelries

Due Dates and Processes

Make a ranked selection of your categories, Sep 22 [Fri]

- Use the google form [here](#).

Group formation and concept note, Sep 29 [Fri]

- Identify Team name, Team color, and Team animal?!
- Identify team members and everyone's research interests (if already know what type of object/iconographies/sites/routes/itinerant objects, identify them)
- Discuss the inclination of the team's interests (i.e. why interested in X, what draws you to Y)
- Note: this is the only group exercise before the final presentation in Scalar, but the team should work together helping each other in finding resources and sharing them. Consider your team members your cabin mates on a sea journey. Discuss emerging themes along the journey to ensure coherent presentation in the final project that will be published on the course Scalar site.

Anatomy of the Tamil Buddha (writing assignment 600-800 words), Oct 20 [Fri]

This is your chance to practice how to write about art. This exercise will help you prepare your entries. Put the visual literacy skills that you are acquiring in this course to use and read the image carefully. Visual analysis requires you to verbalize what you see and this starts with looking at the image carefully. Allow minimum 20 minutes to look at the image – I recommend setting a timer to give yourself at least 20 minutes. Let the image speak to you, and you will be surprised how long you can spend on looking at a single object. You should contemplate on its visual and physical features, the traces of time on its surface, the ambience, the light, and the environment. What is your response, emotional or otherwise to this looking exercise? What contributes to arousing such a response? What are the questions that you would like to ask the image's (unnamed) makers, the patron or the curator who installed the image? Consider what is the most prominent visual features of the image and consider how to describe the image most effectively and systematically to convey how it works. If you are new to art history, you can find additional information about the practice of visual and formal analysis in Sylvan Banet, *A Short Guide to Writing About Art*, Chapter 2, Analysis.

First Draft of Database Entries due by Nov 17 *Consult the **Rubrics** Below

- Check in session during Weeks 9 & 10
- Data Entry Template for minimum required number of entries should be filled for review.
- Make sure the geodata and the date data have been sufficiently researched and seek consultation from Prof. Kim and Tori if needed.
- Suggestions for revisions and edits will be returned by no later than Nov 22
- Start planning the group presentation display scheme

Final Project Submission due by Dec 8* Consult the **Rubrics** Below

- The team project [page with paths] with complete entries/items should be published to the course Scalar site. *at this point the site is not yet public. We will discuss how to and whether to make the site and the data public.
- Images, image source credits, all the hyperlinks must work properly and documented fully in the template.
- Design elements for the team's project page should be cohesive and easy to navigate.

Reflection Essay due by Dec 11

- A short write up (500-600 words) about the experience and what you have learned through working on the project. You may include what you think worked well, what you wish you had done or known about while working on the project, and suggestions for assignment improvement for the next iteration of the course.

Rubrics

	A	B	C	D
Research	Have a clear understanding of the field of research to locate the chosen item in history. Delve deeply into digital and non-digital archives and have done all necessary readings to write the entry.	Understand the field of research to locate the chosen item in history but the scope is somewhat limited. Have looked at several digital and non-digital resources and scheme the contents to write the entry	Have limited understanding of the field and relied heavily on digital encyclopedic references like Wikipedia and Britannica.	Have little to no understanding of the field and no effort was made to consider any resources other than the first few entries of a google search.
Writing	Writing is clear and without any typos. It articulates	Writing is somewhat clear and without any typos but tend to	Writing is awkward in places and does not	Writing is difficult to follow with grammatical

	historical, art historical, and cultural significance in a concise but eloquent manner. It includes original observations and demonstrates their capacity to do visual analysis.	get verbose without being articulate. It includes some original observations and elements of visual analysis.	demonstrate any mastery of the material at hand. It shows some efforts to convey original observations.	and syntax issues. Little to no effort to convey any original observations.
References	Each entry includes minimum five references, and each reference is cited clearly following the agreed-upon style (Chicago Manual). References are cited consistently across entries. Quality of references is high, citing sources other than those readily available on the web.	Each entry includes minimum three references and each reference is cited appropriately. The citation style is inconsistent across entries. Quality of references is mediocre, citing some sources that are truly research-based and includes more popular web-based materials.	Each entry includes minimum three references and each reference is cited but without meeting any citation style requirement. Quality of references is somewhat poor, citing mostly results from single web-search.	Each entry includes one or no reference and it is not properly cited. Quality of references is poor, relying heavily on web search results only.
Image quality	Made every effort possible to obtain the best quality image of each item for the project and check all the copyright issues. Utilized library's imaging services	Image qualities are mixed with some original/high-res images and some poor native images from random websites but made efforts	Image qualities are somewhat poor, including poor native images from web-search without making any efforts to find a better image or	Image qualities are poor throughout, no effort has been made to get better images for the project.

	when necessary and consulted with a Fine Arts librarian and/or the professor to check each image's appropriateness and quality.	to clear copyright issues.	checking any copyright issues.	
Soundness of data	Each entry's data is carefully prepared and entered. All required fields are filled and proofread. All necessary hyperlinks are included. Accuracy of the data has been researched and sought help to verify the accuracy of the data from the professor and other researchers when in doubt.	All required field are filled but it contains typos and minor errors. The original source data is not acknowledged fully or misrepresented. Accuracy of the data has not been fully vetted, but some efforts have been made to verify the data.	Required fields are filled rudimentarily and with typos and errors. Original source data is not acknowledged properly. accuracy of the data has not been vetted but some research effort was made.	Required fields are rudimentarily filled and they are copied and pasted from other databases without checking the accuracy of the data or fitness to the project's data template. No effort to research or acknowledge the source is made.
Cross-checking related contents	All known related contents are cited/tagged whenever appropriate. Efforts are made to make thematic connections across different entries and into different categories.	Related contents are cited and tagged sporadically. Some efforts are made to make thematic connections across different entries and categories.	Related contents are cited and tagged but no efforts to make connections across different entries and categories.	No related contents or tagging. No efforts to make thematic connections.

Presentation of research in Scalar	Everything above is implemented, and all the relational paths/tags are properly marked	Everything above implemented. Some relational paths/tags are worked out but not exhaustive.	The data appears in scalar without any relational paths/tags with errors and inconsistency.	No input in Scalar.
Creativity/Design of the data presentation	Uses images and text layout creatively for clear delivery of the content	Basic layout options are followed, and data is comprehensible.	Data is presented haphazardly and difficult to follow.	None

Up to 5 extra points for identifying new items, sites, stories, routes, or digital resources that are not introduced in class.